

The TRCO Communication Framework

Whitepaper

Clear thinking to structured communication

Today, Real Conversations Create Outcome.

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Part of the Security Communication Stack

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What is TRCO?

Most communication frameworks start with a story. TRCO starts with a **position**.

That single shift moves you from narrator to consultant. You stop reporting what happened and start arguing what matters. TRCO works for any question type, any domain, and any audience. No story required.

Pillar	Function
Thesis	Take a position first. One declarative sentence. No hedging.
Risk	Name what is at stake and why it matters. Frame as exposure, not backstory.
Control	Your response to the risk. The decision, the action, the intervention.
Outcome	Proof the control worked. Quantified where possible. Tied back to the thesis.

The Four Pillars in Practice

Thesis

"A team without clear accountability does not underperform. It drifts."

Risk

"We had six people on the project and no single owner. Decisions kept getting revisited and momentum kept stalling."

Control

"I assigned a named decision-maker per workstream and set a weekly checkpoint with a published log visible to the whole team."

Outcome

"Delivery time dropped by three weeks and the team stopped bringing the same questions twice."

These examples can come from any field. The structure is the same regardless of domain.

How to Apply TRCO

Behavioral questions: Tell me about a time...

Open with Thesis as a claim about what you believe. Let the story prove it. Close by circling Outcome back to the original claim.

Situational questions: What would you do if...

Open with Thesis as your position on the right approach. Risk is what breaks without it. Control is your prescribed response. Outcome is what good looks like when it is executed correctly.

Executive briefing

Same structure, different labels. Thesis replaces agenda. Risk replaces background. Control replaces recommendations. Outcome replaces next steps.

Apologetics and debate

Thesis is the claim. Risk is what is at stake if the claim is wrong. Control is your evidence. Outcome is what the evidence proves.

The Three Tiers

10 seconds: Thesis only

"A plan without a named owner is not a plan. It is a suggestion."

30 seconds: Thesis, Risk, Control headline, Outcome headline

Lead with the position. Name the exposure. State the response. Deliver the proof.

2 minutes: Full TRCO

All four pillars with specifics, numbers, and domain evidence. This is the senior-level answer. This is the executive brief. This is the standard worth building toward.

How TRCO Compares

vs STAR

STAR tells a story. TRCO makes an argument. Senior interviewers want arguments.

STAR assumes you have a story. No story means no answer. It ends at Result, which works for mid-level evaluations. Senior interviewers are not grading your past. They are evaluating how you think about risk, make decisions under pressure, and translate complexity into action. STAR shows what happened. TRCO shows why it mattered.

	STAR	TRCO
Opens with	Situation	Position (Thesis)
Requires story	Yes	No
Covers situational	No	Yes
Senior posture	Narrator	Consultant

"STAR gets you to the interview. TRCO gets you the offer."

vs CARL

CARL adds reflection. TRCO adds diagnosis. Reflection looks backward. Diagnosis drives forward.

CARL earns its upgrade over STAR. The Learning component forces self-awareness and shows growth, not just output. For behavioral questions, CARL is better than STAR. But CARL still needs a story. Remove the story and the framework has nothing to hold. TRCO does not need a story. It needs a position.

	CARL	TRCO
Requires story	Yes	No
Covers situational	No	Yes
Opens with	Narrative	Thesis
Closes with	Learning	Outcome tied to thesis

"CARL makes you sound self-aware. TRCO makes you sound like the person who already knows what to do before the problem arrives."

vs RCS

RCS slows you down to buy time. TRCO gives you something to say when the time comes.

RCS (Rephrase, Clarify, Structure) is a process framework. It tells you how to approach the question. It does not tell you what to say inside the answer. After you Rephrase, Clarify, and Structure, you still have to answer.

Without a content framework underneath, you are improvising inside a neat process.

	RCS	TRCO
Question type	Situational only	Both
Function	How to open	What to say
Output	Organized approach	Argued position
Requires story	No	No
Closes with	Structure	Outcome tied to thesis

The integration play

RCS and TRCO are not competitors. They are sequential. RCS is the entry. TRCO is the engine.

"Rephrase the question. Clarify the constraint. Then deliver your answer in TRCO structure."

That is a complete senior-level answer system for situational questions.

The Thinking Layer

TRCO is the communication layer. Clear speaking requires clear thinking first.

Before you speak, pair TRCO with a structured thinking framework for your domain. TRCO is the output. Your domain's thinking framework is the engine.

For security practitioners, the framework is the **5W Security Framework**. The table below shows how the two connect.

TRCO Pillar	5W Source
Thesis	Why → the governance mandate
Risk	Where → the threat intelligence
Control	What and Who → control selection and accountability
Outcome	Back to Why → the continuous improvement loop

github.com/adammckinski/5w-security-framework

Universal Application

TRCO was developed through a security and GRC lens. It applies universally.

Any career field. Any high-stakes conversation. Any domain where position, risk, response, and outcome matter. Theology. Law. Medicine. Sales. Leadership. Every domain has a thesis, a risk, a control, and an outcome. TRCO gives you the structure to name them in real time.

"If the world is your stage and people are your critics, your job is not to please everyone. It is to communicate your position so clearly they have to take you seriously."

— Adam McKinski

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STAR, CARL, and RCS are existing frameworks referenced for educational comparison. RCS developed by Jeff Su.